

your display. Now, use the Paint Bucket tool to paint the canvas pure black. Press <F11> to make the image full screen. What you're looking for are faulty pixels that stay lit continuously. No lit pixels? Well, now rather, rinse, repeat with white to check for dead pixels, followed by pure red, green, and blue to check the subpixels for any issues. The white and black screens can also be used to test for colour cast and excessive backlight bleed issues (make sure the room is pitch black before testing), which can be unfortunate since these make seeking replacement a bit harder depending upon your display manufacturer.

If you do find any dead or lit pixels, check the manufacturer's warranty for replacement policies. Some manufacturers will replace units with any number of wayward pixels within the first seven days. Others such as Dell have a zero tolerance policies, which guarantees panel replacement even if one stray pixel shows up during the warranty period. Few others such as Asus demand multiple dead pixels to be clustered in one area before you can even demand for replacement. Therefore, it pays to verify these policies before making a purchase decision, seeing as even one dead pixel in the centre of the panel can ruin an otherwise perfect display.

Ditch the Horrible Factory Settings

Hurray to the nice quality assurance dude, who seems to have done an impeccable job of ensuring that your display was absolutely problem free. But wait, your display isn't perfect yet. Not even by a long shot. It's common knowledge that the default settings on the TV are deliberately calibrated to shine through the bright fluorescent lights. The picture appears gaudy thanks to oversaturation and have their brightness and contrast settings exaggerated, with noise filtering and sharpness settings turned all the way to eleven. In short, every display out there (this is especially true for TVs) – no matter how good it actually is – is calibrated to appear absolutely horrendous out of the box.

This is where you can either go the whole hog and invest in a good calibration/testing Blu-ray such as Spears and Munsil HD Benchmark 2nd Edition or Digital Video Essentials HD Basics. If you have invested. If you have even deeper pockets, or have made a substantial investment in a colour accurate professional monitor or a monstrously large and hence expensive TV, it's a great idea to invest in a good display calibration tool such as Datacolor's Spyder colorimeter, which can set you back by around fifteen to twenty-five grand depending upon the features. If you're not committed to spending a